Session 23

2025-09-28

1 – At Barlon's door

~13:30, 11 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The party stands at a tavern under heavy rain; two beautiful women huddle under the eaves while the common room is reserved for a private party. Nuberroca and Mialee are inside talking with **Barlon**, the innkeeper, while a noble and his three guards sit at a table near the hearth, a curious lamp on the tabletop giving off a soft blue glow.
2. Barlon apologises: the rooms, the common room, and the stables are all paid for, nothing to offer, he can only ask them to leave. The noble and his retinue snicker at the caravan's misfortune.
3. Nuberroca refuses the eviction with a flop onto the nearest bench, lying comfortably on it and closing his eyes. He warns Barlon the noble's party has yet to be called to heel for the insults: *"bastante que no les parto el cuello a esos cuatro monos que tienes ahí insultándonos"*.
4. One of the bodyguards approaches Barlon and Nuberroca to order the innkeeper to vacate the room. Mialee uses the covering distraction. An unseen hand slips into the standing bodyguard's pouch and lifts it clean. Nobody at the table marks the loss.
5. Nyx, Amidamaru, and Eguzkilore approach the two women under the eaves, the halfling breaks the ice and the women introduce themselves — **Arietta Innevar** silent on the left, **Zelina Innevar** doing the talking.
6. The sisters are bound for Waterdeep, turned away like the party and left under the eaves with no better place to go. Eguzkilore keeps the conversation shallow — a lie when a lie is safer, the truth otherwise — and pulls them a few steps from the door.
7. The guard commands Barlon to clear the room again; the tavernkeep rounds back on Nuberroca to beg him out, pushing weakly against a mountain that will not move. The guard enforces the eviction kicking the bench under Nuberroca: *"animal, fuera"*.
8. Amidamaru picks the argument up from the door — a bodyguard's job is not to call other races animals, that is racism and bad raising. The guard rebuffs him — proper respect goes to people who follow the rules, not to animals.

2 – Three windows

1. With the eviction complete, Nuberroca swallows the kick and turns to the door. Amidamaru is clear — Barlon is not the one at fault, and there are other ways to settle a thing like this.
2. Nyx pries the sisters for what they know: two or three hours out in the rain since it started, and a half-caught title for their rude host — a Lord, with a northern-sounding name they could not quite pin.
3. Not knowing they are already paid for, Nyx scouts the stables: plenty of room, and five horses standing — one more than the noble's party.
4. Amidamaru casts *Invisibility* on Munin and sends him up to the windows to find where the noble sleeps and where his belongings are. Three rooms in use upstairs — two lit, one dark — each with lodgers' belongings. Only the easternmost has someone inside: a hooded figure in rich robes reading on the bed. The other two sit empty.
5. Mialee opens the climb with a grappling hook off her thieves' kit — the wall is bare and difficult but she manages. She goes in through the dark window first. The take is quiet work: a well-worn armour and a handful of silver she *almost* leaves.
6. She tries to cross to the second window and falls — catches the rope on the way down, reaches the ground without serious injury, and goes unspotted. She climbs back up for the other empty lit room and finds a similar haul: ten pieces of gold worth taking, armour she leaves this time.
7. Outside, Nuberroca works a window from below like a child baiting a cat — calling out hello to the little mice in their burrow — and nobody indoors stays composed about it.

3 - The duel breaks

~14:30, 11 Nightal 1489 DR

1. One of the guards comes out, draws his longsword, and warns Nuberroca off — *"mide tus palabras, escoria"*. Nuberroca lets the fury take him, settles his polearm on the ground, and tells the guard to kneel and ask forgiveness or come get him.
2. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca comes down on the guard recklessly and lands the first strike with devastating force, toppling the man flat on the ground. His second strike comes down on the guard, he turns the blade to avoid a killing blow and the man goes down unconscious instead. He grins over at Nyx — *"non-lethal damage, did you see?"*
3. He vanishes into a cloud and reappears behind the standing guard, waving — *"cucú"*. **Lord Zelan**, the noble, immediately says *"oh, so we can use magic... perfect!"* and the two remaining guards close around the goliath.
4. While holding the blue lamp, the noble speaks a line the party hears but cannot understand. Nuberroca feels an odd pull against the back of his mind but manages to hold it off.
5. One of the mage-guards cuts under his polearm with his sword, flashes behind him, and lays two shortsword hits across his back. Nyx cannot land either of her thrusts with the sword — the noble's clothing seems to hide armour underneath. She marks him as her quarry and holds her line. Eguzkilore prepares his bow but holds the arrow, hesitant to shoot, while asking the ladies to move further apart.
6. ***[EPIC]*** The noble utters words without moving his mouth, and Nuberroca starts shrieking. The barbarian sees the ground under him open — the people of his tribe rise out of it as undead, skeletons and zombies with the faces of his companions and friends tearing at his skin and flesh. He drops his polearm, screams names the party does not recognise, and tries to tear things off himself that are not there.
7. Eguzkilore, hesitant to act, keeps his arrow notched but doesn't let it fly. Nuberroca teleports in a last attempt to escape the hands of his phantasmal friends, but the hands that are not there finish what they started and he drops face-down and bleeding.
8. Nyx is at his side a step later. She kneels, pops one of her berries between his lips, and he comes around just enough to breathe, a blue glow starts closing the worst of his wounds. The noble calls his guards off — point made, no more to prove — picks up his lamp, and the four of them carry their fallen man back inside.

4 - After the fight

1. Nyx opens the tavern door and asks Barlon for a few minutes of his time. The tavernkeep comes out with food and clean cloths for Nuberroca's cuts, the apology still on his face.
2. Amidamaru asks him about the *Company of the Boar* and describes the three riders: the leader in fine clothes with a large tusk pendant hung at his chest; the warlock in hood and robes; and the paladin in religious trappings. Barlon has not heard the name, but when Amidamaru describes the warlock the tavernkeep hedges — a man of that look might match one of the current guests, though he could not say for certain.
3. Nuberroca looks Barlon in the eye and tells him flat: *"la fuerza no basta contra las sombras"*. Barlon does not know what to make of it. The barbarian explains that he is afraid of necrotic magic — leaves what he actually saw out of it — and Barlon simply nods.
4. Watching the goliath worried for his friends, Nyx leans close: it was wizard tricks, nothing real about his village. Nuberroca cannot take the reassurance clean — the vision had the faces of his tribe as undead, and the doubt that it was a true seeing stays in him. Nyx asks whether he said anything about his tribe aloud in the fight; he answers no.
5. Nuberroca asks whether there is a way to verify. Nyx recalls Sinsong once reached a man in Waterdeep with a magical message; perhaps he can carry one to the tribe tonight.
6. Mialee joins them from the back of the tavern, finds Nuberroca half-wrecked on the cart, and reports what she had been doing while they were being broken — rooms searched, nothing more interesting than armour and small coin. Amidamaru floats the quieter half of the report: one of the upper guests, a hooded figure reading in his room, may be the Company of the Boar mage from the description.
7. Nuberroca thanks Nyx in front of everyone — the only one who stepped in to help was her — then catches Amidamaru's eye: he had tumbled one without killing, was that enough? Amidamaru brushes his belt with his artificer magic, lifting a soft light out of it: *"te lo has ganado"*. Nuberroca walks it over to Barlon to show it off like a child.

5 – Supper by the carts

~17:30, 11 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The caravan spreads out beside the road for the night: the next tavern is two days further on and was under construction last time they passed, so the merchants will rest here through tomorrow before pushing on. The two sisters move their belongings into the stable — Barlon's apology never became a bed — though they stay out with the merchants through the afternoon.
2. Nuberroca narrates the duel for the party: he had opened with honour, four closed on him together, and the noble invented he had used magic. He wants Eguzkilore to answer for keeping his bow silent — he had shouted an order to shoot the one casting on him. Eguzkilore says the shout was confusing and he was hesitating, so he kept the arrow for next time.
3. The party puts the pieces together on the enemy. The noble himself carried the lamp and spoke the mind-breaking words; the hooded reader upstairs matches the Boar's warlock from the description. Eguzkilore and Nyx would wait for the morning; Amidamaru wants the lamp tonight, with the noble asleep, using Mialee's unseen hand. The night plan wins.
4. Through the afternoon the two sisters move along the camp, trading life-stories with anyone who will share. Nyx opens up about her nomad tribe; Eguzkilore stays as cautious as he had been at the door. Mialee keeps a careful distance — a greeting, no more — and tells the party afterwards that the two women do not sit right with her.
5. Amidamaru asks the sisters about the Boar's three riders, Zelina confirms they came through fast on the main road a while back. He offers the party as paid protection the rest of the way to Waterdeep for a few coins; the sisters say they are poor as rats, all their money spent on reaching this far, and ask instead if the party could *lend* them something. Nuberroca cuts in to help — the sisters could sell their services. Nyx elbows him; Nuberroca, oblivious, points at his loincloth and clarifies that he means mending work for his torn clothes.
6. By sundown the party splits. Nuberroca beds down with the caravan family he had been camped beside; the other four stay up to prepare the night move. Before sleep Nuberroca has Sinsong send a magical message to his village to ask whether they are safe.

6 – A little blue man

~01:30, 12 Nightal 1489 DR

1. Mialee releases Echo for the climb; Nyx weaves a spell over the four of them, a stealth-emanation that leaves no mark on the ground. Amidamaru moves in with Mialee, Nyx and Eguzkilore behind him; Nuberroca stays with the caravan to guard the family he had been camping beside.
2. The tortle works a *Sleep* spell through the window at Lord Zelan; the noble shrugs it off and is up out of his bed to look around, finds nothing, and settles again on his own in time.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee's unseen hand works the window latch open from outside with her thieves' tools — not a sound carries. The hand reaches in across the room and lifts the blue lamp off the table; she brings it down and gives it over to Amidamaru.
4. The lamp is a small lantern of four glass panes, and inside it an old wizened fellow in a sage's robe, blue-skinned, no larger than a bat and wide-eyed as if the world had just arrived. Amidamaru asks his name in Common, then has Nyx ask it in Sylvan; the mouth opens as if screaming but no sound comes. Mialee catches a whisper near her ear, barely at the edge of a word she could pick out.
5. Mialee says the whole thing is giving her a bad feeling. Amidamaru hesitates — whatever this is, letting it loose beats leaving it in the hands of the man who broke Nuberroca. Mialee sends Echo across to the other rooms and a moment later whispers to Amidamaru: the robed figure from the other room has got up.
6. ***[EPIC]*** Amidamaru opens the lantern door, sets it on the ground and steps back — *"eres libre, muchachito"*. The little blue sage lifts both hands and sends a small point of blue light up along the air; it hangs above them for a half-second and bursts into a sphere of cold. Four of them are caught in it; Nyx and Mialee dodge the worst, Amidamaru and Eguzkilore are engulfed. The sage climbs out of his lamp and goes back in through the second-storey window as the guards begin to stir.
7. They melt back under Nyx's cover. A heartbeat later the guards sweep lanterns in cones of light across the ground; a voice sounds in the night — *"who goes there?"* — but the stealth spell holds and the beams find nothing. Mialee wipes the frost off with her magical trick.

8. Back in the safety of the shadows, Nyx turns on Amidamaru: why the lamp? — he had not wanted the man who broke Nuberroca to keep whatever this was. The puzzle sits between them: imprisoned in the lamp, and then back in it by his own will. Mialee presses — was the lamp his cell or his house? Did it even have a bolt? Perhaps they had freed a man who had not asked to be freed. Amidamaru takes the lesson; Nyx grants she would have done the same. Eguzkilore wonders what the little sage was doing all that time with his mouth open — perhaps something inside the lamp as well.

7 - Village's reply

~09:00, 12 Nightal 1489 DR

1. Barlon tells Mialee at breakfast what she already feared — Lord Zelan's party has paid for two more days, two hundred gold up front. The caravan plans to rest the horses another day and leave at midday. The sisters have asked to travel with them and the merchants have made room.
2. Mialee had tried one further thing at breakfast — a sent whisper to the stranger upstairs, with her comprehension ready for whatever he answered, asking whether he was there against his will. No reply came back, and she took the silence as his answer: not kidnapped, not for them to free.
3. Nuberroca steps away from the group to hear the reply Sinsong had received during the night. The village holds — losses as usual, no breaking — but the undead attacks have grown heavier and more frequent, and lately bald men with facial tattoos in red cloaks walk among the undead at the attacks.
4. He pulls the party in and tells them the whole of it, then remembers that the elegant cap on the noble's head is red. Nuberroca puts the pieces together out loud — bald, red-clothed, cruel with the mind — and asks the party whether this is their fight.
5. Nyx recalls a name she once heard — red mages out of a place called Thay, dangerous and not kind people — but the information is not enough to make the noble one of them. Amidamaru, Nyx and Mialee all push the same way against a second fight — not everyone bald is cruel, not everything red is bad, and the caravan on the road is a larger obligation than the lesson.
6. Nuberroca holds his anger, says he will not drag the party into another fight, not after yesterday. He wants to grow strong enough to answer this kind of magic the next time it comes for him or his.
7. Mialee tells the goliath the lamp story — he had slept through the heist. He asks whether the little sage is held captive; Nyx is not sure, the lamp may be his cell or his house, and he had chosen to go back in. The barbarian floats taking the lamp if its tenant wants to stay. Mialee cuts the thought: the sage had not asked to be freed.
8. Amidamaru lays out the darker read — the sage was the source of the cold he threw at them, and perhaps also of the magic that broke Nuberroca at the duel; best to keep him as far away as possible. Nuberroca lands on the inference: so you are saying the lamp-man was the one who attacked me?
9. The party eats, settles, and spends the rest of the day resting and chatting with the caravan and the two sisters. The next day, at noon, they roll out.